DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Why Does the Soul Still Have Questions?

Daat Tevunot §1-9

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §1-9 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 5 September 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Opening the new series

The twice-weekly Monday and Thursday shiurim resume in September 2022 with a new book, Daat Tevunot. Two years earlier, after Sukkot, the group began Derech Hashem, also by the Ramhal, and spent two years on it. Daat Tevunot (published in English as *Knowing God's Plan*) is an extension of that book and goes into greater detail, but it can be understood without having learnt Derech Hashem first.

Who was the Ramhal?

Before learning any book, the Rabbi says, you have to understand its author. - The Ramhal lived about 250 years ago and died young, at only 39, yet reached what the Rabbi calls unparalleled levels of Torah and Kabbalistic knowledge. - He was a Western Sephardi who grew up in Italy. He was learned in the wider world as well: he went to university and wrote poetry, including 150 poems on Kabbalah, modelled on the 150 chapters of Tehillim. - He was a child prodigy who spoke about very deep Kabbalistic matters while still young and unmarried. This was the early 18th century, only about 50 years after the Shabbetai Sevi scandal, when a charismatic false messiah captured most of the Jewish world, and people had learnt that Kabbalah in the wrong hands can be dangerous. The Ramhal came under great suspicion and pressure. He left Italy, spent time in Holland, and finally went to the Land of Israel for the last three or four years of his life, where he died in an earthquake in Akko.

The Rabbi's own view: the Ramhal is a later replica of the Rambam. No writer in Jewish history is as organised, structured and precise as the Rambam, and the Ramhal is the closest to him in later generations. The difference is that the Rambam did not use Kabbalah in his language, while the Ramhal did.

What kind of book is this?

- Daat Tevunot is essentially a Kabbalistic book, yet you will not find a word of Kabbalah in it. The Ramhal takes the ideas, strips away the technical terms and formulas, and brings them down to simple words so that anyone can follow. It is structured, it is philosophy, and it is Kabbalah at the same time.

- Its subject is mainly hashgahah: how God interacts with this world, what our purpose is, what happens at tehiyat hametim, what happens when Mashiah comes, and reward and punishment.
- One principle runs through the whole book and through all of the Ramhal's thought: the unity of God, yihud Hashem. Nothing can happen in this world without God wanting it.
- The book is written as a dialogue between the Neshamah (the soul) and the Sekhel (the intellect). The soul says: I believe things, but when I look around the world I do not see them reflected in reality. The intellect replies: let us go through them. It is a journey that the reader goes on together with the author.
- There are no chapters, only numbered paragraphs, each opening "amrah haNeshamah" (the soul said) or "amar haSekhel" (the intellect said).

The soul's request (§1-5)

The soul opens with the verse from Vaethanan: "Veyadata hayom vahashevota el levavekha," know it this day and bring it down into your heart, that God is the Lord. Knowing things in theory is not enough. We know a great deal from childhood about God, reward and punishment and Mashiah, but the heart is where we experience reality, and what we know intellectually has to be brought down into how we feel and live. The soul says: my desire is to settle these things in my heart, and I want you to help me.

The intellect asks: which ones? There are 13 principles of faith. The group went through them together, and the soul then lists the ones it both believes and understands, about nine of the thirteen: - God's existence, His unity, and His eternity (He always was and always will be). - That He is entirely outside physical attributes. As the Rabbi has asked before: can God catch a cold? No, and "can't" here is not a lack; He is simply not subject to anything physical. - That the world was created and has not always existed. - Prophecy, the prophecy of Moshe as the greatest of the prophets, and that the Torah is from heaven and will not change.

What the soul does not understand (§5-7)

The soul then names what it believes only "mipenei hovat hadat," because it is commanded to: hashgahah, sekhar veonesh (reward and punishment), the coming of Mashiah and tehiyat hametim. "Look at the words he uses," the Rabbi points out: I believe because I was told to, but I want you to give me logic that will settle me.

This is the Ramhal setting the scene for his own book. He decided to write about these four subjects, so he frames the soul as content with the rest and troubled by these.

In §7 the soul explains its problem. "Hasibot hagedolot," the great events that keep turning in the world, seem to show the opposite of hashgahah: political upheaval, suffering, earthquakes, illness. It looks as though God has abandoned the world and let it run by itself. And beyond that, the soul cannot see the purpose: what does God want from us, where is He leading us, and what is the end point of it all? The Rabbi notes how raw this sounds, as if the soul has come to therapy and is letting everything out.

The intellect's caution and the soul's reply (§8-9)

The intellect answers that these are deep questions, the very questions of "saddik vera lo, rasha vetov lo," why the righteous suffer and the wicked prosper, which the prophets asked and even Moshe Rabbenu asked. Straight away it sets expectations: I will answer as much as I can, but not everything has a clear answer.

The soul replies in §9 with what the Rabbi calls the Ramhal's whole philosophy in one paragraph: I am not asking you to teach me every detail. At the very least I want the kelalim, the principles, the big picture. With those I will have a clear recognition, and for the vastness I cannot understand, I will say to myself that I do not have to finish everything.

The Rabbi stresses this method: learn principles first and the details will fall into place, rather than collecting details and then trying to fit principles to them. In the discussion that followed: - A participant compared it to naaseh venishma, doing before understanding. The Rabbi agreed, but added that you still need the principles: there is no point in someone keeping all the misvot without believing in Hashem. - Another participant noted that in Talmud, principles let you work your way to a final answer. The Rabbi agreed that this is different. Here the principles do not always lead to an end point. Even after learning every explanation of why the wicked prosper, you can never take one person's life and say "this is happening because of that," because there are too many variables. "No one can ever answer Iyov why you specifically are suffering. I can give you general principles."

Summary

- Daat Tevunot extends Derech Hashem: deep Kabbalistic ideas about God's rule of the world, expressed in plain language as a dialogue between the Neshamah and the Sekhel.
- The Ramhal, in the Rabbi's view, is the later counterpart of the Rambam in structure and precision, with Kabbalah added.
- The soul's goal is "vahashevota el levavekha": to move what it knows intellectually into the heart.
- It accepts most of the principles of faith but struggles with hashgahah, reward and punishment, Mashiah and tehiyat hametim, because the world seems to show the opposite.
- The method of the book is to seek the principles, not every detail; specific cases like Iyov's suffering will never be fully explained.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/goEFHkAEreA · More shiurim: rabbikada.com